Wasteman and garbageperson: script

Premise; a competition of who can love the most

Players; both are in service of the municipality to rid the streets of trash, always work in a pair, usually start their day at 5:30 in the morning
1. Wasteman
- likes to drink coffee, strong & hot, enjoys every cigarette
- only picks up things off the ground in pairs of two similar objects, otherwise he lets it lay there
- wears thick pants, and likes to wear something to cover his head
- before he starts cleaning up, he spends a moment looking at the sky
- gives money to homeless people
- believes in beauty & God
- feeds pigeons
- can speak fluent Italian
- only reads books by male authors (not on purpose)
- lived on a farm in his past life
- looks at the ground, mutters to himself a lot

2. Garbageperson
- very tall & lanky
- an aura of trash around him, he leaves it behind like a small tornado
- often walks way ahead of Wasteman, but also routinely falls behind
- stops to look at ants
- likes to drink coffee, but lets it get cold before he drinks, smokes only halves of cigarettes
- slurps loudly
- leaves poetry books behind in odd places
- tries to clean up very hard, but mostly creates more chaos
- likes to whistle songs, usually something he heard on the radio that morning
- believes in love at first sight

Set; around 30 m2, an ecosystem the two players create and recreate, different spaces but also the same ones at the same time; the only importance being that the space is insular, self-contained, for instance:
- a café with a wooden floor
- the concrete coast of a beach
- an abandoned alleyway

Props;
- two brooms made of willow branches
- an apple
- trash and garbage

Costumes;
- two almost identical bright green shirts with logos of the municipality on them, only distinctive in differences of wear and use
- a dark blue hat with flaps for protecting the neck and ears

Music;
- background sounds of the space, brushing of the broom
- ‘troepmens’, a percussion soundtrack

First Act;

From the distance, around the corner of a bay, Wasteman and Garbageperson shuffle along. Actually, you could say only W is shuffling, weary from the early rise, with critical narrow eyes, as G is leaping, throwing stones into the water, and looking at bugs crossing the tiny pebbled road. The sun is just rising, and the air is still cold, despite this being a Mediterranean country. On the coast of the beach, which is built from concrete, there is just one solitary swimmer, doing tai chi on his towel. W and G take no notice of him, and continue their morning routine. W is removing a plastic bag from the metal bin, while G is looking at a colony of ants brining food into a hole in the rocks.

G: ‘As a kid, I thought there were two red ants in my head’

W: ‘Hmh.’

G: ‘I didn’t believe in God perse, but I thought they would punish me if I did something wrong, for instance, if i stepped on the crack in between tiles…’

W has successfully removed the plastic bag, only one quarter full, and placed a new one in its stead. He sits on the ledge of the concrete and rolls a cigarette.

G: ‘Did you think about God as a kid?’

W averts his eyes from G while lighting his cigarette. G is pretty sure that W has never been a kid in his life, and came to existence a week before becoming a garbageman.

W: ‘I didn’t think of God in the Catholic sense, but I was sure something made the universe.’

W takes his time talking, and is slowly getting over his morning grumpiness. He likes how inquisitive G is, he likes that G listens to his answers.

W: ‘So I would sit, and think about how everything came to be. Life before culture, evolution making us crawl from the seas, the Earth coming forth from the Big Bang, and then I guess… God, who caused the Big Bang, but I always got stuck here. Who made God? My forehead would burn from the impossibility of this paradox.’

G is still crouching next to the ant colony. He thinks about what W said for a bit, and then stands up in an explosive movement. He goes to his broom, and starts sweeping the concrete, but from his sleeves fall empty cigarette packs, crumpled up receipts, and those tiny half-rounded plastic bits that keep oil bottles closed… W sighs, and takes out his cigarette while standing up.

W: ‘I can never keep up with you…’

The words don’t reach G’s ears, he is cleaning in a frenzy and the letters of W’s sentence all fly into the vortex that is G’s movement;

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And so the real routine begins; there is no swimmer on the coast anymore, there is only W and G, G moving in fast, erratic motions, and W sweeping methodically, slowly, with a minute attention to every square centimeter of this concrete beach, in a movement as if he is waltzing with the broom. G seems oblivious to his surroundings, but you can catch a glimpse of his smile when he sees W’s concentration on the task at hand.

Second Act;

The scene is still somewhere in the Mediterranean, but not the same beach anymore. There is a path above the rocks, the rocks are above a slightly grey, slightly unsettled sea. Crabs are frantically scattered on the rocks, entering and emerging from the sea. There is a strong salty wind blowing, in the area they call it *jugo*. (This wind has been known to drive people crazy; when the Republic of Dubrovnik still existed, crimes committed while *jugo* was blowing got a lower sentence, on account of the unpredictability of peoples actions during this weather) There is a sound in the background, looming, electrical, a persistent zooo—oo- ooh-oo- oohm. The sound is circular, with every round it gets louder. We encounter W and G, standing opposite each other, some 2 and a half meters apart, both standing at an angle as if they are leaning on an invisible wall. They are staring at each other. They have been standing like this for approximately 15 hours. Their gaze is unbroken, W’s eyes are slightly muddy. They are trying to get closer, in mind. They are calibrating to each others’ frequency.

Third Act;

We find ourselves in an empty café. All the chairs are on the tables, or were supposed to be. Some lay scattered around a table on which a paper coaster has been used for an ashtray, some lay sideways on the ground. Empty, half empty, and full beer glasses are placed on all surfaces; on the bar, on the tables, on the chairs on the tables, on the piano that isn’t tuned anymore, on the windowsills. W and G

enter through the fire exit, with cleaning trolley in hand. Looking past all the mess, W walks to the bar.

W: ‘A coffee to start?’

G: ‘Yes, please.’

W starts making the coffee, waiting patiently for the coffee grinder, smelling the scent thoughtfully. He makes an espresso for himself, and a big americano for G. They sip the coffee, W overlooks the café and is making an inventory of what to do; put the chairs back on the tables to make it easier to clean the floor, then start sweeping, and mopping, then put the chairs down and clean the tables… When he turns around to look at his companion, G is not there anymore, but in the opposite corner of the room, standing on a table, reaching for something high. W decides to finish his espresso and start working.

As the rhythmical thudding of the chairs being put back into their place starts, W is humming in a low voice.

W: ‘Volare…’

G finishes the tune by whistling.

W: ‘Can ta
re

Ooo ooh…’

The brooms bristle while they’re cleaning the hardwood floor. W is fascinated by the patterns in the wood, he notices that the floor has been repaired, as there is one strip of a panel going perpendicular to all the others.

W: ‘Fe lice
di stare
lassù’

He looks to the back of G, forgotten sunglasses are flying around, G is removing the glasses from one place and leaving them in the opposite corner, there is a scarf getting stuck behind a lamp while G is trying to sweep… He returns his eyes to the floor.

G: ‘W!’

W: ‘Yes?’

G: ‘I have something for you.’

G takes out from his pocket, while some loose keys fall out, a red shiny apple. The sunlight reflects off of it, and it looks like the most perfect apple ever made.

W: ‘Where did you get this from?’

G: ‘I picked it from up there, in the corner!’

W looks, and indeed, there is a tiny tree growing where G was rummaging some time before. W accepts the apple, his eyes damp from emotion.

W: ‘Thank you, friend.’

W puts the apple in a handkerchief, and the package into his pocket. They sweep and they clean, and things keep falling from G’s pockets and sleeves, and they sweep and they clean.